

cate over paid short messages through cellular networks, the founders of WhatsApp wanted to build an app that sends and receives SMS-like messages over the Internet for free from anywhere on the planet. For cash-strapped netizens on the back of a recession, this was music to everyone's ears. Obviously, it didn't take long for WhatsApp to replace every default SMS app people were using on their phones – and within just over a decade 2 billion people and over 400 million Indians use WhatsApp to send billions of messages every single day.

NOT JUST WHATSAPP, BUT AIRBNB & UBER

The link to a recession company is even more strong with the likes of Airbnb, the startup that began life to provide cheaper alternatives to travellers than expensive hotels. I have personally used their service in the early 2010s when work-based travel took me to different countries around the world, and I've always found Airbnb as a great way to meet local hosts and experts, and explore a city less like a tourist and more like a local. The origin story of Airbnb is pretty interesting, if you didn't know.

According to an Inc article, Brian Chesky and Joe Gebbia had the idea of renting out an air mattress in their San Francisco living room in 2007 – only their idea was far beyond the likes of Couchsurfing (a free travel stay service similar to Airbnb). Little did they know that December of that year would be the start of the Great Recession and open a door to



an opportunity – allowing displaced Americans affected by the housing market collapse to get a much needed roof over their head. Airbnb revamped the market of short-term living quarters for those who were priced out by hotels, and the rest as they say is history. Despite getting affected by the last two pandemic years, Airbnb still has over 150 million users around the world and close to 3 million registered hosts.

The story of Uber is also very similar: Originally started as Ubercab, Garrett Camp and Travis Kalanick founded the ride-hailing company (which has now branched into things like food delivery) towards the end of the recession based on a frustrating personal experience of being unable to find a taxi at night in Paris. In the beginning of its life, Uber only focused on catering to business executives trying to commute within the city – providing them high-end luxury cars at just twice the price of a

regular taxi fare. Of course, later this idea was expanded to compete with regular taxis across the world by enabling a fleet of vehicles through just a location-based app service. And the rest is history, as Uber went public in 2019 (within just a decade of its life) for a whopping \$75 billion – one of the most highest priced IPOs in the history of startups.

Today, Uber has just under 4 million drivers around the world, a large portion of which enrolled in it as an opportunity to earn money or create additional income for themselves, just as a sizable workforce in the US were laid off on the back of the 2008 Great Recession. Uber came at a perfect time for all of them, even customers trying to save time and money, and starting their recovery beyond the financial crisis

It's not just these tech companies – Microsoft in 1975, Apple in 2001 and 2008, Google in 2001 and 2008 have all come out of marquee recessions during the period of their existence with renewed vigour and ahead of most non-tech companies. Technology inherently provides you the tools to re-invent and pivot yourself, your businesses, especially when times are tough – like over the past two years of the pandemic and the feared incoming global recession. Just look at video-conferencing app Zoom, which no one had heard of before 2020 – and how its usage just shot through the roof all over the world. It wouldn't have been possible without the coronavirus pandemic-led demands to work from home. 

